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To cite this article: Jahfar Shareef Pokkanali. (2020) Sailing across Duniyāv: Sufi Ship–Body Symbolism from the Malabar Coast, South India, South Asian Studies, 36:2, 125–138, DOI: [10.1080/02666030.2018.1495872](https://doi.org/10.1080/02666030.2018.1495872)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/02666030.2018.1495872>



Published online: 02 Aug 2018.



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Sailing across Duniyāv: Sufi Ship–Body Symbolism from the Malabar Coast, South India

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The paper examines Sufi ship–body symbolism in a painting on the wall of an eighteenth-century mosque from the riverine hinterland of the Malabar coast as well as in two poems, one in Arabic and the other in Arabi-Malayalam, produced in the region. Focusing on the intricate details of the painting and poems, the paper shows how the ship's semantic field (sea, storm, pirates, pearls, shore, and so on) is connected to everyday Islamic rituals and mystical ideas and beliefs. In discussion, the paper draws attention to the creative hermeneutics of the local Muslim scholars and the use of an imagery which has a deep resonance in the intellectual history of Islam as well as in the littoral–cultural context of Malabar. The paper highlights the need to include imageries and motifs from inside the mosque when looking at artistic agency in the mosque architecture of the region. The paper argues that the ship painting in the spatiality of the mosque and in the Arabi-Malayalam poems is intended to induce wonderment among its audience, and thereby to inculcate ethical and pietistic dispositions among them.

Keywords: Sufism; ship motif; Islamic art; Malabar mosque; littoral Islam; Muslim vernaculars

Introduction

The origin myths of Muslim communities in the littorals of the Indian Ocean are woven from journeys through the sea undertaken by companions of the Prophet, Sufis, and scholars, of perils and miracles, shipwrecks and sea-crossings, on prayer rugs.¹ With regard to the Muslims of Malabar, the ship is a significant symbol connected to the story of the arrival of Islam to the region. They believe that Islam reached its shore very early, during the time of Prophet Muhammad himself. This story goes back to the 'ship' that arrived on the Malabar coast carrying a few companions of the Prophet who established mosques along the coast.² Recent scholarship has highlighted that the Malabar coast was a significant node in the premodern networks which facilitated a circulation of Islamic texts across the littorals of the Indian Ocean.³ It was not only a site of trade and commerce, but was also a thriving network of *ulemā* (scholars) and Sufis who played a significant role in the spread of Islam in the region.⁴ It was an important site for the production of Islamic knowledge in Arabic and Arabi-Malayalam (Malayalam written in a modified Arabic script). While the Portuguese were beginning their voyages, Arabic was the lingua franca of the ocean.⁵ However, with the inroads made by the Portuguese power in the western Indian Ocean and the loss of Arab trade supremacy in the region, from the sixteenth century onwards, *paradesi* Muslims (foreign origin) began to leave the ports of Malabar, and the local

Muslims (Mappilas) gained from this displacement. Sebastian Prange speculates that this could have led to a change in the production of Islamic knowledge within the Malabar community with the rise of local *ulemā* and the dissemination of their works in Arabi-Malayalam.⁶ Nevertheless, *ulemā* with Arab lineage, such as the Makhdūm clan from Yemen who were writing in Arabic, continued to be highly influential. It is within this context of a premodern Malabar that was turned towards the sea that the paper looks at ship–body symbolism and the theme of 'Journeying to God' in a ship painting on the portico wall of an eighteenth-century Malabar mosque and two Muslim literary texts produced in the region. The paper looks at the creative elaboration of the ship motif in the region and also, by placing the ship motif inside the Malabar mosque, seeks to draw out the agency of the producers and consumers of cultural productions on the Malabar coast.

The early use of ship/boat motifs in the art and architecture of the Indian subcontinent can be seen in 'Buddhist monuments and on coins and sealing' from the second century CE. They are also to be seen in the Ajanta paintings and Aurangabad sculptures.⁷ Although for the Brahmins, journeying in boats and ships is considered to be a source of pollution, two *Rig-Veda* hymns refer to the 'boats as an imagery of spiritual struggle'. In the *Jātaka* tales, the *Bodhisatta* path and the 'cultivation of perfections' were illustrated through the metaphors of maritime travel and boats.⁸ The use of

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the ship/boat motif in the art and architecture of the Indic traditions in South Asia has been identified in different temporal and spatial contexts. As Sri Lanka was an important node in the networks of Southern Buddhism, and also as a centre of Muslim pilgrimage, the use of ship motifs as religious symbolism could have been familiar to Muslims of the region; however, this is yet to be explored. In the context of the Muslims of South Asia, the use of the ship motif has been recorded in the Maijbhandari Sufi songs from the Bangladesh region.⁹

Within the Islamic traditions, the Qur'an mentions the drifting of ships on the surface of seas as an object of wonder and a sign (*āyat*) which discloses to those who are thoughtful, the majesty and mercy of God (Q: 16:13–14; 42:32–33).¹⁰ Through the use of this motif, the Qur'an seeks to invoke a sense of awe whereby the object of wonder (or sign) leads to contemplation and is conferred a didactic value. As a form of Qur'anic imagery, the ship has been appropriated and used by various Muslim scholars and communities, and remains a favoured imagery in Sufi writings.¹¹

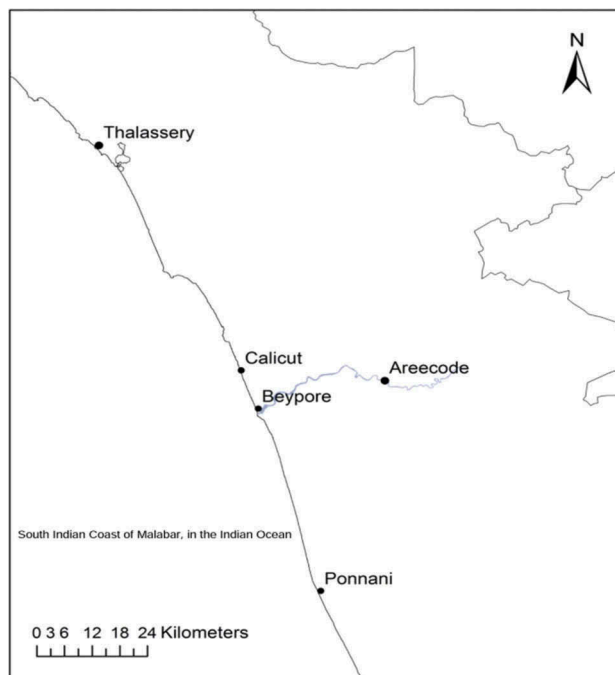
Jasad-ul-Muslim: the ship painting in a Malabar mosque

From the middle of the seventeenth century to the nineteenth century, a 'Kerala school of paintings' developed and there was a profusion of murals on the walls of temples and palaces.¹² In the mosques I visited during my field study, however, and perhaps due to the rampant renovations undergone by the Malabar mosques since the post-colonial period, there are very few images on the walls except in the mosque under consideration in this paper. In an Arabi-Malayalam text, the *Mulhir-ul-Muhimmāt* (*The Revealing of Essential Matters*), published in the beginning of the twentieth century, there is a clear admonition against the drawing of images that beautify the walls, pillars, and the *mihṛāb* of the mosque, which, according to the author, is a *bid'a* or innovation.¹³ The use and engraving of Qur'anic verses and Hadith are seen by him as *karāhat* or 'frowned upon'. This can imply either that there were paintings to be seen in mosques before the text was published or that they were rare. However, most of the premodern Malabar mosques have Qur'anic inscriptions and floral, vegetal, and rare zoomorphic motifs in the inner mosque and antechambers, mainly as part of the woodwork. Some mosques also have poems mainly in Arabic written on the walls of the antechamber and portico and very rare inscriptions in Arabi-Malayalam.

The ship painting under consideration in this paper is to be found on the portico wall of the Thazhathangadi Mosque (which means mosque in the lower bazaar in Malayalam) in the present town of Areecode, in

Malappuram district, Kerala. Areecode (Figure 1), part of erstwhile British Malabar, is the name for a cluster of villages which constitute the local administrative unit as well as the name of the main town. The town is located thirty-six kilometres eastward from the historic port city of Calicut (Figure 1) (now Kozhikode). The river Chāliyār (Figure 1), flowing through these hinterland villages, was significant for the transportation of timber to the port, especially for the ship-building industry.¹⁴

The Thazhathangadi mosque (Figures 2–3) is one of the important congregational mosques in the town. According to local historians, the land for the mosque was gifted by a Hindu landlord to a Sufi saint for curing his daughter of a fatal illness. It was initially built as a small mosque in the early decades of the eighteenth century. A larger mosque was later built beside it in the middle of the eighteenth century, which is the mosque used for worship in the present. Similar to many other premodern Malabar mosques, members of the Makhdūm family were appointed as the *qādīs* (judges) of this mosque, but this is not so in the present.¹⁵ This mosque was again significantly expanded or rebuilt at the end of the nineteenth century as writings on the exterior wall of the antechamber indicate. In its structure, it resembles other premodern mosques in Malabar. Although in the last two decades, the mosque has undergone several renovations, its old layout has not been affected by modern expansions.¹⁶ The main construction material is laterite stone and timber. This mosque is a two-storey building



1. Map of the South Indian coast of Malabar and the river Chāliyār (Author's image).



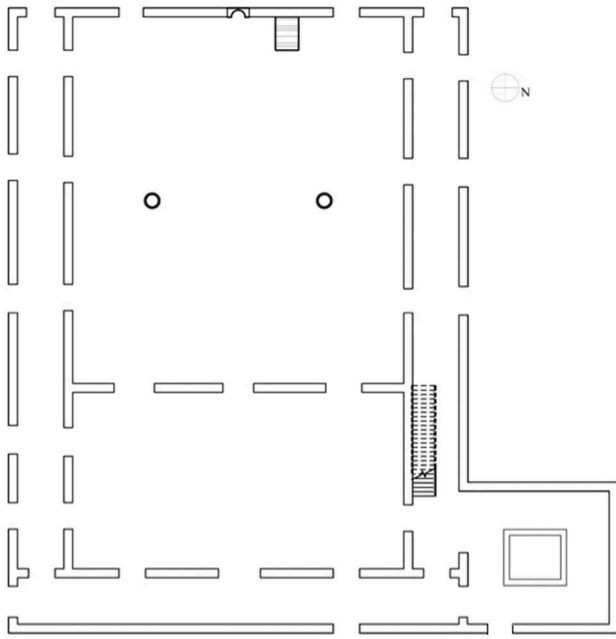
2. The renovated area of the mosque, view from the southeast (Author's photograph).



3. The second floor of the mosque with the gable, view from the northeast (Author's photograph).

in which there are three doors into a portico with arched openings, one from the south side which connects the mosque to the street, from the front courtyard on the eastern side of the mosque, and another one from the

ablution chamber. From the portico, there is an ante-chamber which leads to the main prayer hall and two corridors running along either side of the prayer hall and antechamber (Figure 4). On the non-hypostyle mosques

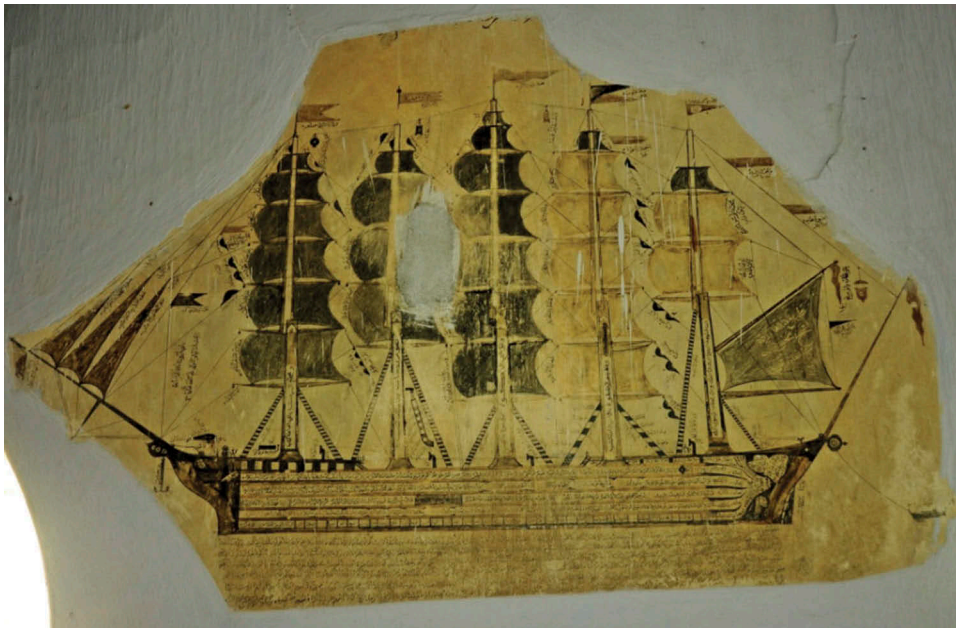


4. The floor plan of the mosque (Author's image).

of India and the larger Indian Ocean, in an interesting paper, Lambourn observes that the portico and antechamber establish a 'strong central axis, perpendicular to the qibla' and 'creates an intermediary transitional space between the prayer hall and exterior of the mosque'.¹⁷ This spatial strategy, according to her, separates the main prayer hall from the other areas, which

resembles the ritual boundedness of the *garbhagriha*, a distinctive Indic feature of early mosques of the subcontinent.¹⁸ In the Malabar mosques, these intermediary spaces often have religious and historical inscriptions written in Arabic.¹⁹ It is in this intermediary space of the portico of the Thazhathangadi mosque that a few Arabic calligraphic images and four mural images – two ship images and the images of two of the most sacred precincts of Islam (the Masjid-al-Haram of Mecca and Masjid-al-Nabawwi of Medina) – are to be found. Unlike the main prayer hall and the antechamber, in the portico, people can spend time socializing without being concerned about disrupting the sanctity of the inner mosques.²⁰

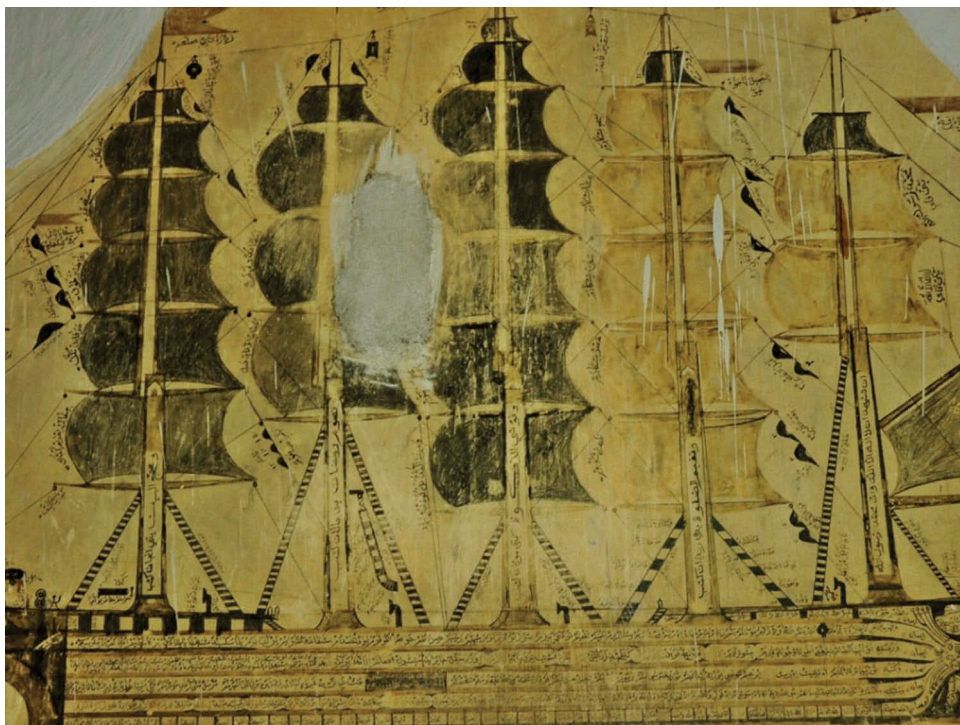
The paintings are attributed to a wandering (*sanjāri*) scholar, Hāji Beypokāran Unnimāyin Kutty, who completed the paintings after he returned from the Hajj pilgrimage. Not much else is known about him and it is generally believed that he died around the end of the nineteenth century.²¹ Unlike the other images, only one of the ship images (Figure 5–7) has extensive annotations and descriptions, above, below, and on the image. The writing is mainly in Arabi-Malayalam. This ship painting is seen on the arched interior wall of the portico. It is at a height of 1.5 metres and covers an area of 1.45 metres in width and one metre in length. The text at the bottom of the image instructs the spectators on how it should be viewed. The text begins with a disclaimer that discourages attempts to read the image in its literal anatomical sense. Instead, it beckons the believer to see the five pillars of Islam and the six



5. Jasad-ul-Muslim: the painting from the mosque (Author's photograph).



6. Arkān-ul-Īmān, the six floors of the ship (Author's photograph).



7. Arkān-ul-Islām, the five masts of the ship (Author's photograph).

articles of faith in the Sunni creed in the five masts of the ship and the hull of the ship, which is divided into six floors, respectively:

Oh 'brethrens' (*ikhwānīngale*) who look at the ship named '*jasad-ul-Muslim*' ('the body of the believer') which is in the sea of this mortal world (*'dunyāv'*), making a similitude with the body (*jasad*) does not mean that it is equating your hand, leg, eyes, and nose. The meaning of equating the body of believer is as 'six articles of the faith' (*arkān-ul-īmān*), (hull) this ship has six floors (Figure 6), pronounce them sequentially (*tartīb*) from the bottom to up and similar to the five masts (*kombu*) of the ship (Figure 7), see the five pillars of Islam (*arkān-ul-Islām*), pronounce them...!²²

A feature of interest about the ship depicted is that it is a fully rigged European ship that has been used to elaborate on the details of Islamic beliefs and practices. The other incomplete ship painting in the mosque is a steamer with five masts (Figure 8) and smoke billowing out.

The five masts: the five pillars of Islam

The first mast of the ship on the right-hand side of the viewer represents the *shahāda* (the Muslim declaration of faith that 'there is no god but God and the prophet Muhammed is his messenger'). It has two major sails representing the two parts of *shahāda*. The viewer is advised to fix these two sails by using two ladders: 'maturity' (in Arabic, *bulūh*) and 'intellect' (in Arabic,

'aql). There is a flag at the top of this mast with the Arabic word Allah and an additional sail in black projecting towards the bow area of the ship which represents the Qādiriyya Sufi order (*'Tariqathul Qādiriyya*). The Qādiriyya was one of the important Sufi orders which had followers in Malabar, named after the twelfth-century Sufi master, Abd al-Qādir al-Jīlāni (d. 1166).²³ Asserting the significance of Sufi practice, this sail is tied to the mast which stands for *shahāda*.

The second mast stands for the mandatory daily five-time ritual prayer. This mast has five major sails representing the five mandatory prayers and two sail strips for the obligatory prayers. The text tells the viewer that the sails representing the five prayers during the day and night are to be fixed accordingly during their respective prayer times. The obligatory prayer performed after the main night prayer known as *salāthul-withr* is represented at the top of these five sails, and the flag on the top of this mast represents another obligatory prayer, the '*salāth-ul-muthlaq*' (the obligatory prayer performed without any reason). The lantern seen between the flags of the second and third masts represents the auspicious 'night of salvation' (*lailat-al-Barā*) that falls on the night of the fifteenth day of *sha'bān* in the Islamic calendar, the month just before the fasting month of *Ramadān*.

The third mast stands for *zakat*, or almsgiving, and has seven sails. Though the writing has faded and is not easily legible, the sails probably represent the groups to whom alms are to be mandatorily given, while the two ladders attached to this mast stand for the completion of the annual cycle and for those who are gifted with



8. The steam ship (Author's photograph).

wealth. The flag at the top of this mast represents *swadaqā* (giving charity).

The fourth mast signifies fasting and has three main sails, each one representing ten days of fasting of the thirty days in the month of *Ramadān*, while the remaining sail stands for non-obligatory fasting during special days. The ladders attached to these masts stand for the arrival of the month of *Ramadān*, while the other ladder represents maturity and a sound mind. The flag of this mast signifies *fithr zakāt* (almsgiving at the end of *Ramadān*), and the lantern fixed near this flag represents *eid-ul-fithr* (the festival at the end of *Ramadān*).

The fifth mast stands for the Hajj (pilgrimage to Mecca) and has five sails representing the sequence of rituals to be performed during the Hajj. There are two ladders attached to this mast, representing intellectual maturity and the economic and physical ability required to prepare and complete the Hajj. The flag at the top of this mast represents the visit to '*rawdah sharīf*' (the Prophet's tomb in Medina), while the lantern next to this flag represents *eid-ul-adha*' (the festival following Hajj). The three sails attached to the stern of the ship signify the obligatory prayers of *swalāthu-thajjudh* (performed at midnight), *swālath-ul-awwābīn* (performed after the main prayer just after the dusk), and *swālathu-luhā* (performed before the noon prayer).

The hull with six floors: the six articles of the faith

The six articles of the faith are represented by the six floors of the ship. Similar to the masts, each floor of the ship has been detailed through annotation. The floor at the bottom of the hull, which is closer to the keel, represents the belief in one God (*Allah*). The second floor stands for the 'belief in angels of God' (*malāikathi*), the names of the ten archangels and their qualities, which are described. The next floor corresponds to 'belief in the Books' (*kuthubihī*) sent down through God's chosen four prophets; the names of the prophets with the names of their respective texts are written. Also, it is in this layer that it is mentioned that the Sufis (*aw'liyā*) will profess the *dīn* (in Arabic, 'creed' or 'religion') of the Prophet Muhammad until the 'Day of Judgment'. The fourth floor represents the belief in the 'messengers of God' (in Arabic, *rusulihī*) and has the names of the twenty-five prophets mentioned in the Qur'an. The fifth floor stands for having faith in '*yaumul-ākhirā wa yaumul Qiyāma*' (the 'Day of Resurrection' and the 'Day of Judgment') and related eschatological events like seeking the intercession of the Prophet Muhammad (*shafā'ih-ul-kubrā*) during the final judgement, and the basin of the Prophet (*haud al kausar*), as per Islamic eschatological tradition each Prophet has their own basin where their believers quench

their thirst. It is said that the Prophet's basin contains a liquid which is white as milk and sweet as honey.²⁴ The sixth floor stands for faith in the will of God (in Arabic *qadr*) by which all good and evil in worldly life comes to pass.

Other features

In addition to these functional features, the ship has other items and objects coded with meaning which are seen in and around the deck of the ship. These include a hoisted flag representing the act of reciting the Qur'an, a telescope through which one can recognize 'permissible' (*halāl*) and 'forbidden' (*harām*) acts, and seven small flags representing the seven names of God as *dikir* to recite on each day of the week. There is also a warning about four 'pirates' who may hijack the ship and steer it away from the right 'path': these are *iblis*, the cursed-fallen angelic being, other people (in Arabi-Malayalam, '*lokar*'), worldly possessions (*duniyāw*), and 'bodily temptations' (*thadi-icha* in Arabi-Malayalam). The rudder of the ship is connected to the helm near the bowsprit of the ship and, as the annotation clarifies, when the ship is moving in the right direction, its helmsman is said to be an angel, but when the ship drifts away from its 'path', it is said that *iblis* is the helmsman. At the right end of the hull, all the six floors join at a point where the subtle organ of the heart (*qalb*) is represented and it is connected to the rudder and the helm. There is also a drawing of a small local boat (in Arabi-Malayalam, '*thoni*') at the edge of the painting, which the author denotes as *ilm* (revealed knowledge), signifying the inextricable mediatory role of religious knowledge and the agency of its custodians to embark onto the 'ship' and move on the 'straight path'. This boat, which represents revealed knowledge, is the only motif that is original to the region of Malabar. Compared to the large, fully-rigged European ship, this small vessel is essential to reach the ship, which is anchored a little away from the shore.

The painting provides a coherent heuristic of everyday Islamic practices and the basic tenets of Islamic theology and eschatology. The choice of Arabi-Malayalam to annotate the painting and its location in the portico indicates that the painting was intended for the common believer visiting the mosque, as the use of the Arabic language was confined to the circles of learned *ulemā* in Malabar. Although the imagery of the ship in a visual medium is specific to this particular mosque, the use of the motif can be found in the literary texts produced in the region. Before delving into further examples from the region, I intend to give a general outline on the use of the ship motif in the mystical thoughts of Islam.

The itinerary to God: the ship motif in Sufi thought

Within the mystical traditions of Islam, the quest for God is often represented by two types of movements: one, physical horizontal journeys through sacred places and, two, metaphorical vertical journeys or *‘hāl* (spiritual states) within the realms of the mystical experience.²⁵ In Sufi literature, these journeys are denoted as *markab* motifs, literally ‘something to ride’, ‘boat’, or ‘vessel’, from the lexical root of *r-k-b* meaning ‘to get onto a vehicle’.²⁶ In the Qur’an, three terms, *fulk*, *saḥāb*, and *jāriya*, are used to signify the idea of a ship.²⁷ The sailing of a ship is described as a sign of God and used to denote His creative activity and divine mercy, as a source of nourishment, bounty, and ornament (Q: 2:164, 14:32, 16:14, 22:65, 30:46, 31:31, 42:32, 43:12, 55:24).²⁸ The ship is also used as a symbol for the testing of one’s faith such as when the Qur’an says that in times of storm, the faithful pray to Him alone, but when they are safely back on land, the disbelievers ‘turn away’ (Q: 17:66–69).²⁹ This meaning of the ship motif is redoubled through the story of Noah’s ark, which becomes a parable of divine protection and blessings in the midst of wrath and punishment.³⁰ The Qur’an (Q: 18:65) also narrates the story of an encounter between the prophet Moses and a mysterious companion bestowed with ‘God’s Mercy’ (*‘rahmattan min ‘indinā*) and ‘Divine Knowledge’ (*‘min-ladunnā ilm*).³¹ Generally understood as the prophet Khidr, this mysterious companion executes three strange acts in Moses’ company, including the making of a hole in a ship.³² Here the motif of ship is connected with divine knowledge.³³ Braginsky, in his work on the evolution of the ship motif, has shown how the Qur’anic motif has been appropriated and elaborated by mystical scholars through the expansion of the semantic field of the ship such as the sea, storms, favourable winds, pearls, and the shore, which has led to very profound interpretations.³⁴ For example, a variant of the ship, the ark, is frequently used as a multifaceted symbol in works by the famous Andalusian Sufi scholar, Ibn al-‘Arabi (d. 1240).³⁵ In his *Kitāb al-Isrā* (*The Book of the Night Journey*), Ibn al-‘Arabi includes a chapter titled ‘The Serene Soul and the High Tide’, which gives a description of the *‘saḥāb* (ark) of the Universe.³⁶

Another prominent scholar to have drawn on the ship motif is Shihāb al-Dīn Umar al-Suhrawardī (d. 1234), the Sufi luminary from Baghdad. In his *‘Irshād al-Murīdīn* and *Risāla fi’l Sayr wal-tayr*, the ‘individual paths’ (*turuq*) to the ultimate truth has three sequential stages: *‘sharīa-tarīqa-haqīqa*. He illustrates the tripartite stages of the journey by equating each stage with the ship motif and its semantic fields: *‘sharīa* (legal traditions of Islam) is equated with the ‘ship’, *tarīqa* (individual Sufi path) is equated with the sea, and *haqīqa* (visions of gnosis or truth) is equated with

pearls. Whoever wants the pearls (*haqīqa*) must embark onto the ship (*sharīa*), sail through the sea (*tarīqa*), and plunge into the depths of the sea to gather the pearls.³⁷ Corresponding to man’s ‘psycho-spiritual constitution’, the first stage of the journey is related with the souls (*nafs*), the second with the subtle organ of the heart (*qalb*), and the third with the spirit (*rūh*).³⁸

The transformation of the ship motif in the Quran from a sign to that of the ship as a body traversing the sea of supreme truth is a prominent variant of the ship motif in mystical thought. When the supreme truth is denoted by the sea, the body is an obstacle. To attain the supreme truth, the body has to drown. Braginsky identifies the earliest use of the ship motif in the work of the Egyptian mystic, Niffārī (tenth century). He uses it to represent religious law (the exoteric aspect of faith) and as a general symbol of all secondary causes (veils) that separate one from God. This symbolic identification of the ship with secondary causes, according to Braginsky, has led to the interpretation of the ship as a sign of something external and, thus, less valuable than the internal path to God. The use of the sailing ship to symbolize the physical and mortal body of human beings, thus, has mainly a negative meaning in the Middle Eastern variants of this symbolism, such as are seen in the works the Persian illuminationist philosopher of Shihāb al-Dīn Yahya al-Suhrawardī’s (d. 1191) *Qiṣṣat al-ghurba al-gharbiyya* (*The Tale of the Western Exile*), and Farid al-Dīn ‘Attar’s (d. 1221) *Bulbul-nāma* (*The Book of the Nightingale*), in which a sea voyage results in death.³⁹ However, this motif, when it reached the Malay shores, takes on a positive connotation as seen in the *Syair perahu* (*Poem(s) of the Boat*), in which the ship–body is portrayed as a vessel endowed with a soul.⁴⁰ The soul-sailor navigates the path. Here, it is the body that mediates the journey to the afterlife. Braginsky links this positive interpretation and the prevalence of ship/boat imageries in Malay Sufi literature to pre-Islamic use of ship imageries in the region, where there was ‘not only a “congenial substratum” in their culture, but a kind of powerful resonator which immediately singled out this particular symbolic theme from a great many others [...] it emphasized precisely those shades thereof which had been completely effaced in the Middle Eastern literature by that time’.⁴¹

Sufi ship–body symbolism from the Malabar coast

From the evidence of Sufi ship–body symbolism from Malay Muslim contexts and the Majibhandari Sufi songs of Bangladesh, the wider circulation of Sufi ship motifs in the littorals of the Indian Ocean world is already evident. However, to place the ship motif of Malabar in a shared cultural context of the premodern

Indian Ocean world, this section of the paper traces the use of the ship motif seen in the visual medium (*Jasad-ul-Muslim*) to two early uses of ship motifs seen in two Sufi literary texts from the region: one, an Arabic poem, *Hidāyat al Adhkiyā ilā Tārīq al-Awliya* (*Guidance of the Intelligent to the Path of Sufis*) authored by Zyn al-Dīn Ibn Ali (d. 1522–23), and the second, a vernacular Arabi-Malayalam poem, the *Kappappattu* (*Ship-Song*) by Kunchāyin Musliyār (d. 18th century).

Hidāyat al Adhkiyā ilā Tārīq al-Awliya⁴²

This is the first use of the Sufi ship motif in a text produced in Malabar. It was written in the later part of the fifteenth or early sixteenth century by Zyn al-Dīn Ibn Ali, a prominent member of the Makhdūm clan which settled on the coast of South India. Initially, they settled on the Coromandel coast and later moved to Cochin (now Kochi); however, they flourished in Ponnani (Figure 1) on the coast of southern Malabar, a town which earned the title of the ‘Mecca of Malabar’ through its association with the Makhdūms. Ibn Ali trained initially in Ponnani and later in Calicut. He travelled through many centres of Islamic learning in the Middle East before finally returning to Ponnani. The poem was in circulation within the networks of the premodern Indian Ocean region and reached as far as Java and Egypt.⁴³ In the poem, Ibn Ali describes the way to God as a continuum of *sharīa-tarīqa-haqīqa*:

Certainly, the way to God consists of *sharīa-tarīqa-haqīqa*,
Hear them through these exemplars:
Sharīa like a ship, *tarīqa* like the sea,
And *haqīqa* like precious pearl from the sea.
Whoever aims for the pearl will embark on the ship
And dive into the sea to find the pearl.
Oh Brethren, *tarīqa* and *haqīqa*
Are unattainable without *sharīa*.
To illuminate the inner heart with the light of God,
You should beatify the external body with *sharīa*.⁴⁴

This is based on the works of Shihāb al-Dīn Umar al-Suhrawardi (d. 1234). Ibn Ali characterizes the Sufi path as three broad and subsequent stages of ‘*sharīa-tarīqa-haqīqa*’, which unfolds within the spatial and temporal frames of a sea voyage. The *sharīa* is likened to the ship, the *tarīqa* to the sea, and the *haqīqa* to a precious pearl from the sea. The indispensability of *sharīa* in the journey to *haqīqa* is emphasized by Zyn al-Dīn, as also Shihab al-Din Umar Suhrawardi, in which the externally visible (*zāhir*) body is to be adorned with the *sharīa*. Later in the poem he mentions that to let the ‘light of God’ (*nūr tajalli*) reach into the inner (*bātin*) subtle organ of the *qalb* (heart), one needs to remove its darkness.

This conceptualization resonates with Suhrawardi’s two ‘modalities of human existence’: the interior and exterior dimension, the intellectual or mental (*wujūd al-dhihnī*), and the physical or corporal (*wujūd al-aynī*), respectively.⁴⁵ Rather than elaborating on the varying aspects of the spiritual states and stations as does Suhrawardi, Ibn Ali’s focus is more on the praxis (*amal*) to be undertaken by those who seek to journey on to God. So, along with the *sharīa*, in his poem, it is the exemplary prophetic model that is emphasized. He begins his advice by listing virtuous acts and elaborating on them. The acts essential on the mystical path are seeking repentance (*ta’wba*), practice of ritual austerity (*kin’ā*), renunciation (*zuhd*), seeking religiously sanctioned knowledge (*ilm-ul-sharh*), and the keeping of the Prophet’s *Sunna* (tradition), trust in God (*tawakkul*), piety and fear, seeking solitude, to be wary of time. In his elaboration on the *Sunna* of the Prophet, according to Ibn Ali, the way to perfect oneself is by following the science of the Sufi path (*tassawuuff*). This is likened by him to the practice of *adab* (‘proper manners’) based on the Prophetic model. To deepen knowledge about the Prophetic example and to appropriate *adab* into everyday social relationships and interactions, he advises his brethren to read the *Awārif Ma’ārif* (*The Knowledge of the Spiritually Learned*) by Suhrawardi as well as the compilation of the Hadith, the *Riyādh-u-Sālihīn* (*Garden of the Righteous*) by Imām Nawawī (d. 1277), the Damascene Shafi’ite jurist and Hadith scholar. Similar to Suhrawardi, Ibn Ali also portrays self-exertion or the ‘greater jihad’ (*mujāhadat*) conducted against the body’s attraction to worldly profanities as an inextricable component of attaining *mushāhadat* (direct witnessing) of *haqīqa*.

The imagery of the ship and its semantic field are not further elaborated in the work of Ibn Ali, its use is limited as a strategy to convey the conceptual structure of the three interconnected components of the Sufi path. However, they are not original as can be seen, and as the direct mention of Suhrawardi in the poem by Ibn Ali himself suggests. Further, the use of classical Arabic must have limited its circulation to an elite literate class (merchants and scholars) well versed in Arabic.

Kappappattu of Kunchāyin Musliyār

The *Kappappattu* (literally ‘ship song’) is an eighteenth-century text written in the vernacular Arabi-Malayalam. The poem also has many words in Arabic, Persian, Tamil, and Sanskrit. It was authored by Kunchāyin Musliyār, born in Thalasseri of north Malabar (Figure 1). Although the exact time span of the poet’s life is unknown, there is evidence that he trained under

the auspices of the tenth Makhdūm of Ponnani, Shaik Nūrudhīn Makhdūm (d. 1740), which places him in the eighteenth century.⁴⁶ As the title of the poem indicates, the allegory of the ship is the central theme of the text and he begins the poem with these lines:

Those who are immersed in thoughts of one's Self
Think hard and shake off the mantle of laziness
From matters of this world; throw away sensual darkness
And walk forth with pristine thoughts.
We have a ship, nine measures in length,
Crafted in exact beauty from keel to prow.⁴⁷

The motif of the ship is extended by the author in two directions – one, the ship is likened to a living body made up of internal and external organs travelling to the shores of the afterlife and, second, the path through the sea, where the semantic field of the ship is expanded to include the winds, pearls, pirates, whirlpools, etc. This can be a parallel to the two modalities of the self as in the work of Umar al-Suhrawardi as well as in Ibn Ali. In the body metaphor, Musliyar equates the hull and keel of the ship to ribs and backbone; the heart, brain, and other sense organs are equated to the pegs of the ship. The veins and capillaries traversing the body are likened to the planks sewn together, a feature common to the dhows of the western Indian Ocean, especially before the arrival of the Portuguese, who introduced nailed planks. He then talks about the nine orifices of the body of which three are the most to be guarded. This reference is to guard the mouth and what it says and eats and the sexual organs as in a Hadith of the Prophet; this is also to be seen as the two desires of the body – food and sex in the section of the ‘breaking of the two desires’ (*kasr-al-shahawatyn*) of the *Ihya-ulūm-uddīn* (*Revival of Religious Science*) of the philosopher-Sufi, Al Ghazzālī (d. 1111).⁴⁸ The author then talks of the crew in the ship – those who can guide the ship on its way, the insightful shipmaster (*nākhoda*), the captain (*mu'allimi*) sets the course of the ship, and two writers (*kārrānī*) do the accounting duties, referring to the two angels who record each human action. The helmsman (*sukkāngir*) sits at the front and the lookout man (*panjārī*) warns about coming threats. Some of these terms appear in the medieval Arab navigator Ibn Mājid's manuals for seafarers.⁴⁹ In the poem, quite similar to the painting, five masts are likened to the five pillars of Islam. The second mast, which represents the canonical daily prayers, is elaborated on to give details about the time (represented by winds) of the prayers. The six articles of faith are not mentioned, as in the painting. After the five masts are elaborated, the ship docks for a while at the ports of Mecca and Medina, after which numerous verses are eulogies to

the Prophet Muhammad. The poet's love for the Prophet is clearly seen in these lines. Interspersed between the elaboration of the features of the masts are mentions of the Day of Judgment, such as the verses below, which resemble the Qur'anic verse (Q: 36:65):

On that day, the angels will chain your legs,
On that day, the writer(s) will hand over the books,
On that day, the bigoted will cry out,
On that day, children would be left uncared
On that day, hands will speak out,
On that day, legs will give witness.

Unlike the painting, in the poem, Musliyar can easily move back and forth between the two shores, from the ‘Worldly’ to the ‘Otherworldly’, thereby affirming their interrelated nature. As in the painting, he also mentions four pirates (*iblis*, worldly possessions, other people, and bodily temptations) who cause obstructions to the ship and deviate it from its path. These four pirates can also be traced to another Arabic text (attributed to Zyn al-Dīn Ibn Ali). Referring to Imām Al-Ghazzālī's *Minhāj al-'Abidīn*, this text is locally known as *Minhāj Sakhīr* (*The Small Minhāj*). It is based on Al-Ghazzālī's main text and he elaborates the four main ‘barriers’ (*‘awa'iq*) on the way to God.⁵⁰ In a vernacular poem, this entailment of *‘awa'iq* on the way to God with pirates is interesting in the context of Malabar, where the maritime trade was continually affected by piracy.⁵¹ The poet then instructs the believer to keep a canon made of *tawakkul* (trust in God) in the ship, and, when the pirates attack, to fill the canon with gunpowder (*dhikr*) and to ignite it with *zuhd* (abstinence from worldly pleasures). This resembles the greater jihad (*mujāhadat*) as seen in Ibn Ali's poem. To reach that most desired of destinations, the poet says that it is essential to have knowledge about seafaring, like favourable winds, the locations of magnetic whirlpools, and underwater pearls. This could be a reference to the *haqīqa* of Suhrawardi and Ibn Ali. Musliyar also gives a description of the eternal charms of ‘the garden’ (*al-firdaus*, or paradise) which awaits those who successfully cross the sea, which is juxtaposed with the eternal torments of ‘the fire’ (*nar*, or hell) awaiting those who drift away from the path. As with the painting, in the poem, when the ship is steered to the right, the seat of the helmsman is occupied by an angel, and when it is turned to the left, the seat is occupied by the *iblis*. He also discusses the ‘balance’ (*mīzān*) and the ‘[b]ooks of good and bad’, the intercession of the Prophet (*shafā'a*) for the pardoning of sins, and the Prophet's basin, where the believers can quench their thirst on the last day. He assures his brethren that a ship with all its sails firmly hooked will reach that most desired of destinations in

the 'garden of paradise' (*al-firdaus*). As in the painting, the poem also portrays the moment of seeing (*liqā*) the light of God as the most desired by all in paradise. The poem ends with the lines below:

Oh Allah!
 May I be blessed to be graced by your presence
 In the company of Your beauteous Prophet.
 Oh Allah..!May I see your light?
 In the company of the Prophet send for all the worlds.
 Grant me my prayer of blessed encounter with You,
 In the company of your blessed messenger.
 Grant me a death full of faith
 And belief in your blessed Prophet's creed.

In various places in the poem, the poet calls himself a *pottan* (fool), such as in this verse:

When the kite is cut, can you still fly it, oh fool?
 When the bridge breaks, can you still cross, oh fool?

Through these lines, the poet humbles himself before God and his messenger. Although the poem does not directly refer to *tassawuf*, his imaginative use of various concepts within Sufi discourse and the emotive nature of the lines clearly put the poem in an intertextual relationship with the work of Ibn Ali and the larger Sufi tradition. In the above lines, the body's mediatory role on its way into the afterlife is clearly seen. At the end of the journey, the boat sinks down onto the sea-floor and finally into the ground. In the poem and in the painting, the body has a positive and negative connotation. Its mediatory role is essential and, if disciplined through the various practices enjoined in the painting, the *kappappattu* and the adornment of the body by the *sharī'a*, the adoption of proper *adab* as advised in the *Adhkiyā*, the path is clear. However, if bodily desires are not vanquished, the ship would not reach its destination. Similar to Braginsky's observations of the Malay, the negative and positive connotations of the ship-body symbolism are found fused together in the poems and the painting from Malabar.

Discussion

The Malabar mosque and, through it, discussions about Malabar Islam has usually focused on the outward form of the mosque. On the outside, the Malabar mosque has a distinct resemblance to the Hindu temples of the region. This has been the observation of most scholars who have studied the Muslims of Malabar.⁵² A prominent example of this observation and its subsequent interpretation of the Mappila variant of Islam can be

shown in a quote by Stephen Dale. He writes, the 'evolution of the community through the conversion of poor fishermen, labourers, and most numerous of all, impoverished tenant farmers and agricultural labourers [...] such individuals would have been accustomed to accept prevailing temple architecture as the "natural" form for ritual centers or the outward symbol of sacred space'. Dale portrays this form of architecture as incongruent with Oleg Grabar's idea of 'commonly known features' of Islamic art.⁵³ He then proceeds to attribute this perceived alterity, the otherness or non-Islamicness of the mosque's outward character to the Hindu past of the Muslim community. In this analysis, there is a distinct 'unislamicness', 'innocence', 'ignorance' posited to the vernacular mosque and, through a generalization, the local Muslim community. The newer translation approach to study the cultural productions of Muslims in the 'peripheries' proposes the use of the terms 'Indic' and 'Islamic' to look into the complexities of cultural production. While the study of the 'Indic' in the Islamic has contributed to a greater understanding and a complication of the narrative of Islam in the 'peripheries' from deviant to creative, nonetheless, the consistent focus on the 'Indic', especially in regard to the form and structural layout of the Malabar mosque, and the assertion of a 'conservatism of mosque architecture' to the 'distinctive Indic mosque space' are not very different from Dale's argument.⁵⁴ Writing on the translation of the distinct Indic ritual space into the mosques of the subcontinent (of which the Malabar mosque is an example), Lambourn says, 'the translation of this spatiality is perhaps not surprising given that Islamic ritual buildings were commonly constructed by Hindu architects and craftsmen. However, the wide application of the concept and its maintenance over centuries of mosque construction in South Asia indicates that it responded to Muslim usage and expectations.'⁵⁵ However, this has to be further explored, particularly given the fact that even the traditional popular house form on the Malabar coast follows the 'I shaped rectangular' (*ekasala*) layout, which has a 'circumferential expansion around the core in the form of veranda'; hence this feature is not only to be found in the temples or mosques of the region.⁵⁶

To throw more light on the ritual requirements and the mediatory nature of the mosque space, the inside of the mosque space with its imageries and motifs also needs to be attended to. When the motifs and their creative elaboration within local contexts are taken into account, the agency of the local actors and their variant of Islam can be better elucidated. For this, there is a need to complicate the idea of Islamic art through the use of intellectual history in its analysis; this, as Persis Berlekamp puts it, might create an 'overly complicated interpretation', yet it would also at the same

time be able to question the 'nascent canon of Islamic art' as essentially decorative.⁵⁷ Through this paper, my aim has been to point out that the question of artistic creativity (in opposition to the passivity and deviancy of the 'periphery' presupposed in the centre-periphery model) of the agents of production of the architecture of the Malabar mosques should be considered not only in its outward form and structural layout, but also seen in the light of the motifs and objects to be seen inside the mosques as well. The use of the ship painting inside the mosque highlights the creative appropriation of a motif that can be essentially identified as neither 'Islamic' nor 'Indic'. The local *ulemā* utilized a cultural template (i.e. the ship) which had resonance within the intellectual history of Islam as well as within the littoral-cultural context of Malabar. Furthermore, engagement with the vernacular Arabi-Malayalam texts will bring in more understanding to the discussion on vernacular and littoral Islam.⁵⁸

In the region of Malabar, it was the itinerant traders, *ulemā*, and Sufis who were the makers of this particular variant of 'littoral Islam'. The choice of the ship-body symbolism, especially in the poem, *Kappappattu*, and in the painting exemplifies the creative agency of local Muslim scholars who wrote in the vernacular Arabi-Malayalam script. Painted on the liminal space of the portico wall of the Thazhathangadi mosque, the ship painting titled the *Jasad-al-Muslim*, along with the description in Arabi-Malayalam, points to the fact that it was intended for a general audience and even placed strategically as a means to stimulate discussion among its spectators. The painting is an invitation to the spectator to contemplate on the transitoriness of life and a warning to discipline the body on a successful voyage into the afterlife. By inviting its spectators into esoteric ways of seeing and apprehending the world (life) (through allegories and metaphors which were and are often limited to the elite and the literate), the ship imagery was primarily not an object of 'beauty', but rather beauty coupled with awe in which through the 'embedding of the wondrous object in a symbolic framework [...] it functions as an object of wonder'.⁵⁹ As is often observed by scholars of Islamic art, the efficacy of the image lies in its potential to create an aesthetic delight in the viewer and the creation of wonder, which is then connected to ethics and piety. The function of *seeing* through imageries and metaphors is very pertinent to Islamic mystical traditions,⁶⁰ compared to which the aspect of pedagogy is secondary.⁶¹ The painting in the mosque was meant to be apprehended visually as well as intellectually and, ultimately, to inculcate ethical and pietistic dispositions. The informative and pedagogical aspects of the *Jasad-ul-Muslim* painting are clearly evident in the textual descriptions which surround it. Both the poems and the painting use the ship metaphor to convey the tenets of Islamic beliefs and practice. The ship-body symbolism and its entwinement with Islamic everyday

practices and beliefs, with its allusions to peril and temptations in the 'path' and its evocation of other eschatological events, imbues the image(ry) with an affective message through which ethical and pietistic dispositions can be inculcated.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I had presented an earlier version of this paper in a conference, 'Ilm: Science, Religion, and Art in Islam', 20–23 July 2016, at the University of Adelaide, Australia, and an updated version in 'Speech and Space: Discursive Environments across Non-Arab Islam', 7–9 September 2017, at the University of Vanderbilt, Tennessee, USA. I am grateful for valuable comments from Samer Akkach (University of Adelaide), James Bennett (Art Gallery of South Australia), Tony K. Stewart, David J. Wasserstein, Samira Sheikh (Vanderbilt University), Faisal Devji (St Antony's College, Oxford University), Shahzad Bashir (Brown University), and Max Stille (Max-Planck-Institut für Bildungsforschung). I am also indebted to my doctoral supervisor, Julia A. B. Hegewald, and to the anonymous reviewers of this paper. Any shortcomings are my own responsibility. I am grateful to Barakat Trust, U.K. for funding my further field work in the littorals of South India.

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

NOTES

1. Nile Green, 'Saints, Rebels and Booksellers: Sufis in the Cosmopolitan Western Indian Ocean, 1780–1920', in *Struggling with History: Islam and Cosmopolitanism in the Western Indian Ocean*, ed. by Edward Simpson and Kai Kresse (London: Hurst & Co., 2007), pp. 125–59.
2. Y. Friedmann, 'Qissat Shakarwati Farmad: A Tradition Concerning the Introduction of Islām to Malabar', *Israel Oriental Studies*, V (1975), 233–58.
3. Sebastian R. Prange, 'Like Banners on the Sea: Muslim Trade Networks and Islamization in Malabar and Maritime Southeast Asia', in *Islamic Connections: Muslim Societies in South and Southeast Asia*, ed. by R. Michael Feener and Terenjit Sevea (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 2009), pp. 25–47.
4. Ibid., p. 37.
5. Michael Pearson, 'Afterword', in *Struggling with History*, ed. by Simpson and Kresse, pp. 357–72.
6. Sebastian Prange, 'The Social and Economic Organisation of Muslim Trading Communities on the Malabar Coast, Twelfth to Sixteenth

- Centuries' (unpublished PhD thesis, SOAS, University of London, 2008), p. 174.
7. Himanshu Prabha Ray, *The Archaeology of Seafaring in Ancient South Asia* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003), p. 63.
 8. See Sarah Shaw, 'Crossing to the Farthest Shore: How Pāli *Jātakas* Launch the Buddhist Image of Boat onto the Open Sea', *Journal of the Oxford Centre for Buddhist Studies*, 3 (2012), 128–56; see also Sarah Shaw, 'Art and Narrative in Changing Conditions: Southern Buddhist Temple Art as an Accommodation of the New and Diverse', in *In the Shadow of the Golden Age: Art and Identity in Asia from Gandhara to the Modern Age*, ed. by Julia A. B. Hegewald (Berlin: EB-Verlag, 2014), pp. 227–55.
 9. Hans Harder, *Sufism and Saint Veneration in Contemporary Bangladesh: The Majibhandaris of Chittagong* (New York: Routledge, 2011), pp. 254–64.
 10. M. A. S. Abdel Haleem, *The Qur'an: A New Translation* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), pp. 167, 313.
 11. For the use of the ship motif in the Shia tradition, see Khalid Sindawi, 'Noah and Noah's Ark as the Primordial Model of Shi'ism in Shi'ite Literature', *Quaderni di Studi Arabi*, Nuova Serie, 1 (2006), 29–48; also see note 27.
 12. H. Sarkar, *An Architectural Survey of Temples of Kerala* (New Delhi: Archaeological Survey of India, 1978), p. 123.
 13. Mūsā-bin Muhyudīn, *Mulhirul Muhimmāt* (Thalasseri: Mazharul Muhimmāt Press, 1900).
 14. While describing the Chāliyār river (or the Beypore river (Figure 1), as it is referred to as it nears the coast), William Logan mentions Areecode as a place where 'Muhammadan' merchants had settled for ages: see William Logan, *Malabar Manual I* (Madras: Superintendent Government Press, 1951 [1887]), p. 13; Michael Mann, 'Timber Trade on the Malabar Coast, c. 1780-1840', *Environment and History*, 7 (2001), 403–25.
 15. V. Abdullah Kutty, *Areecodinte Qissa: Oru Gramanthinte Samskariaka Charithram (The Story of Areecode: The Cultural History of a Village)* (Calicut: Lipi Publishers, 2014).
 16. A new concrete structure with foliated arches has been added to the southern side of the old mosque. Apart from the main entrance from the street, there is another entrance on the eastern side which was once connected to the river.
 17. Elizabeth A. Lambourn, 'Islam beyond Empires: Mosques and Islamic Landscapes in India and the Indian Ocean', in *A Companion to Islamic Art and Architecture*, 2 Vols. ed. Finbarr Barry Flood and Gülru Necipoglu (New York: Wiley Blackwell, 2017), ii, pp. 755–76 (p. 768).
 18. *Ibid.*, p. 769.
 19. Mehrdad Shokoohy, *Muslim Architecture of South India: The Sultanate of Ma'bar and the Traditions of the Maritime Settlers on the Malabar and Coromandel Coasts (Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Goa)* (London/New York: Routledge Curzon, 2003), pp. 143–246.
 20. The inscription from the portico of the Calicut Jamia Mosque describes it as '*dilhiz*', in Persian it means a 'place between two gates', see Shokoohy, *Muslim Architecture of South India*, p. 180, and Lambourn, 'Islam beyond Empires', p. 769.
 21. I have conducted interviews with the custodians of the mosque as well as with the family members of the scholar; see also Abdullah Kutty, *Areecodinte Qissa*, pp. 24–28.
 22. Author's translation.
 23. As a Sufi order, it was popular in Syria, Egypt, and Yemen and later spread to India, Southeast Asia, and Africa: see Nile Green, *Sufism: A Global History* (West Sussex: John Wiley & Sons, 2012), pp. 87, 148. On the popularity of Abd al-Qādir al-Jīlānī in Malabar, see Prange, 'The Social and Economic Organisation of Muslim Trading Communities on the Malabar Coast', p. 160.
 24. Jane Idleman Smith, Yvonne Yazbeck Haddad, *The Islamic Understanding of Death and Resurrection* (New York, Oxford University Press, 2002), p. 80.
 25. See Jaakko Hämeen-Anttila, 'Journey through Desert, Journey towards God: The Use of Metaphors of Movement and Space in Ibn 'Arabi's *Tarjumān al-Ashwāq*', *Journal of Muhyiddin Ibn Arabi Society*, 37 (2005), pp. 99–125; to see the role of institutionalized 'ritual wandering' (*siyāha*) on the mystical path (*tarīqa*), see Houari Touati, *Islam and Travel in the Middle Ages*, trans. by Lydia G. Cochrane (London: The University of Chicago Press, 2010), pp. 160, 184, 195.
 26. Pablo Beneito, 'The Ark of Creation: The Markab Motif in Sufism', *Journal of Muhyiddin Ibn Arabi Society*, 40 (2006), 21–58; for ship as Markab, see Dionius A. Agius, *Classic Ships of Islam: From Mesopotamia to the Indian Ocean* (Leiden: Brill, 2008), p. 272.
 27. Agius, *Classic Ships of Islam*, pp. 285–89.
 28. Haleem, *The Qur'an*, pp. 18, 160, 167, 213, 260, 263, 313, 316, 354.
 29. *Ibid.*, p. 179.

30. M. A. S. Abdel Haleem, 'The Qur'anic Employment of the Story of Noah', *Journal of Qur'anic Studies*, 8 (2006), 38–57.
31. Haleem, *The Qur'an*, p. 187.
32. The other acts are the killing of an innocent boy and the rebuilding of a demolished wall in a village that spurned them.
33. Vladimir Braginsky, 'Sufi Boat Symbolism: Problems of Origin and Symbolism', *Indonesia and the Malay World*, 26 (1998), 50–64; Vladimir Braginsky, *The Heritage of Traditional Malay Literature: Writings and Literary Views* (Leiden: K. I. T. L. V. Press, 2005), pp. 676–96.
34. Braginsky, 'Sufi Boat Symbolism', 61; Braginsky, *The Heritage of Traditional Malay Literature*, p. 677.
35. Hämeen-Anttila, 'Journey through Desert, Journey towards God', 105–06.
36. Beneito, 'The Ark of Creation', 39.
37. Erik S. Ohlander, *Sufism in an Age of Transition: 'Umar al-Suhrawardi and the Rise of the Islamic Mystical Brotherhood* (Leiden/Boston, MA: Brill, 2008), p. 156.
38. Ibid., p. 157.
39. Braginsky, 'Sufi Boat Symbolism', 52–54.
40. Ibid., 57–62; Braginsky, *The Heritage of Traditional Malay Literature*, pp. 683–93.
41. Braginsky, 'Sufi Boat Symbolism', 54.
42. I have relied on the text, *Adhkiyā* (Thirurangadi: 'Amir-ul-Islam Power Press, 1994).
43. See Annemarie Schimmel, *Islamic Literature of India* (Wiesbaden: Otto Harrassowitz, 1973), pp. 4–5; 'Adhkiya' 'received commentaries both in the Hijaz and in Java: see Aziz Ahmad, *An Intellectual History of Islam in India* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1969), pp. 4–5; see also Kunhali V., *Sufism in Kerala* (Calicut: University of Calicut, 2004), 17–18.
44. Author's translation.
45. See Ohlander, *Sufism in an Age of Transition*, pp. 164–65.
46. Hussain Randathani, *Makhdumum and Ponnaniyum (Makhdūms and Ponnani)* (Kozhikode: Ponnani Juma Masjid Committee, 2014), p. 129.
47. Author's translation.
48. Sahih al-Bukhari, Vol. 8, Book 76, Hadith 481; *Al-Ghazzali On Disciplining the Soul & Breaking the Two Desires, Books XII and XXIII of 'Revival of Religious Sciences' (Ihya' 'Ulum al-Din)*, trans. by T. J. Winter (Cambridge: Islamic Text Society, 1995).
49. G. R. Tibbetts, *Arab Navigation in the Indian Ocean before the Coming of the Portuguese, being a translation of Kitāb al-Fawā'id fī usūl al-bahr wa'l-qawā'id of Ahmad b. Mājid al-Najdi* (London: The Royal Society of Great Britain and Ireland, 1981) pp. 58–59.
50. *Minhāj al-'Abidin (The Illuminated Path of the Worshippers)*, ed. by Mahmud Halawi (Beirut: Mu'assasathu-rrisala, 1989), pp. 83–132; Zyn al-Dīn Ibn Ali, *Minhāj sakhir*, in *Sab'athu-Kuthub*, ed. unknown (Thirurangadi: C. H. Muhammad & Sons, 1994), pp. 2–42.
51. Sebastian R. Prange, 'A Trade of No Dishonor: Piracy, Commerce, and Community in the Western Indian Ocean, Twelfth to Sixteenth Century', *American Historical Review*, 116 (2011), 1269–93.
52. A notable exception is Shokoohy, *Muslim Architecture of South India*.
53. See Stephen Dale, 'Islamic Architecture in Kerala: A Preface to Future Study', in *Islam and Indian Regions*, 2 vols, ed. by A. L. Dallapiccola and S. Zingel-Ave Lallemand, (Stuttgart: Steiner, 1993), i, pp. 491–95 (p. 493); see also Oleg Grabar, *The Formation of Islamic Art* (New Haven, CT/London: Yale University Press), p. 1.
54. Lambourn, 'Islam beyond Empires', pp. 771, 768.
55. Ibid., p. 769.
56. Indah Widiastuti, 'A Study of Living Culture: Typo-Morphology of Vernacular-Traditional Houses in Kerala', in *Sacred Landscapes in Asia: Shared Traditions, Multiple Histories*, ed. by Himanshu Prabha Ray (New Delhi, India International Centre & Manohar, 2017), pp. 199–215 (p. 206); Ashalatha Thampuran, *Traditional Architectural Forms of Malabar Coast* (Kozhikode: Vastuvidyapratisthanam, 2001), p. 83.
57. Persis Berlekamp, *Wonder, Image, and Cosmos in Medieval Islam* (New Haven, CT/London: Yale University Press, 2011), p. 5.
58. Nile Green points out that the historiographical problems of studying Indian Ocean littoral Muslim communities is the technical obstacle of dealing with multiple languages. The study of the ship motif in the mosque compels us to engage with texts in vernacular Arabi-Malayalam as well as in Arabic. This obstacle has to be surmounted to bring more nuance to our understanding of vernacular mosques in the region. See Nile Green, 'Lost Voices from the Indian Ocean', *Los Angeles Review of Books*, 20 January 2017 <<https://lareviewofbooks.org/article/lost-voices-from-the-indian-ocean/>> [accessed 8 February 2017].
59. See Jamal Elias, *Aisha's Cushion: Religious Art, Perception, and Practice in Islam* (London: Harvard University Press, 2012), p. 173.
60. Ibid.
61. Torsten Tschacher, 'Can Om Be an Islamic Term? Translations, Encounters, and Islamic Discourse in Vernacular South Asia', *South Asian History and Culture*, 5 (2014), 195–211.